

When AI Tells the Story of a Handmade Product, Does It Preserve the Artisan's Voice?

Why Are We Talking About This Topic?

Craft Villages as Carriers of Identity

In Vietnam, a traditional craft village is much more significant than a group of people making products; it is a place where skills and local identity are passed from one generation to another. For instance, a ceramic bowl from Bát Tràng may carry the marks of its maker's hands, Vạn Phúc silk depends on knowledge of thread and weaving that has developed over many years, and in Phú Xuyên, families make incense products that connect daily work with local tradition. Not only do these items represent the history and culture of a region, they also help showcase the artisan's identity and story.

Going Digital

However, with the development of technology, artisans are using smartphones to livestream products and to reach customers through social media ("Online Sale Now Irreversible"). For example, in Phường Dực Commune near Hà Nội, craft workers attend weekly classes on online selling in order to sell their products more quickly and easily (Nguyễn and Ngô). Additionally, many craft workers are also learning to edit videos and use AI tools to write product descriptions (Nguyễn and Ngô). With this noticeable change, an artisan family can sell their products at a significantly faster rate since they are able to reach a wider range of customers by selling products online.

What the Shift Might Cost

Although the use of AI and technology might help workshops stay relevant in a digital world, there are several philosophical problems. To be more specific, traditional crafting has never been just a simple occupation, but rather part of the cultural identity of the Vietnamese people. Consequently, when AI algorithms are used to generate product descriptions and the products are sold online, part of that cultural identity might be lost during the process. This essay will further explore the potential problems of craft workers selling their products using AI and the internet through the lens of Walter Benjamin, Hannah Arendt, and James C. Scott.

The Originality Argument

Benjamin on the Aura of an Original

One compelling argument was introduced by Walter Benjamin, a German philosopher and cultural critic who wrote about art during the rise of photography and film. More specifically, in his essay "The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction," he points out that an original work has an "aura," which is the special feeling connected to an object's unique history, place, and presence (Benjamin).

This concept can be applied to handmade craft work produced traditionally. To illustrate, customers who visit a workshop may see the clay on the artisan's hands, the precision of the craft worker's movements, and may hear the stories behind each handmade craft directly from the artisan who created them. These small details can only be recognized by the customer who visits a traditional workshop. On the other hand, a photo online can show the image of an object but cannot give the customer the same experience of being present in a traditional workshop. Consequently, when traditional craft products are being sold online, they are losing their "aura" of being connected to a specific place. According to Walter Benjamin's philosophy, the value of a craft work also lies in the specific environment in which it was made and sold, which is one of many factors that separate an original craft work from the mass produced products online (Benjamin). Additionally, through the use of AI to create descriptions to maximize sales, the AI generates a broad description of a craft to help sell a product quicker rather than narrating the history of the item. This is because concise product descriptions are significantly more eye-catching compared to a long historical paragraph of a craft. Therefore, when a person purchases a hand-crafted object from an online store, they ruin the aura of the object by ignoring the historical aspects of a traditional hand-crafted item. All in all, from Benjamin's perspective, purchasing a handmade vase through a website is no different from acquiring a mass-produced item that could be bought anywhere.

The Invisibility Problem

Arendt on Action and Self-Disclosure

Another important point of view comes from the ideas of Hannah Arendt, a philosopher who studied how human beings show who they are to the world. More specifically, in her book *The Human Condition*, she argued that human activity is divided into different types, of which the most important type is "action". Action is what happens when people speak and act together in public and show their true selves to others. According to Arendt, "action" is important because it fosters a genuine public community and helps people reveal their unique identity as an individual (Arendt).

Under the ideas of Hannah Arendt, the "action" for a craft village is the interaction between the artisan and the customer. For example, when a customer visits a workshop, he or she can speak to the village craft worker, and watch them work through precise hand movements that were learned and passed down from

previous generations. When customers watch the artisan work, the artisan becomes more than a seller and is seen as an individual who has his or her own story and knowledge.

On the contrary, when relying on AI descriptions and buying through social media applications, there is a risk that the traditional craft worker's story and effort could be hidden. An AI description and advertisement video, although they might be able to showcase a product's features and attract customers, fail to share the artisan's personal story (Arendt). For instance, a customer buying a hand-crafted product online may know the colors and price of a vase, but know little about the artisan who spent weeks working on the story behind how the vase was created. As a result, only by purchasing the handmade craft where it was created can the customer learn about the historical story and crafting methods of the product. This matters because craft villages should not be perceived as production factories, but as places where buyers can feel the effort and cultural value that the artisan invested in the product to make it special and unique.

Counterpoint: The Subsistence Ethic

Scott on Judging a Tool by Survival

However, not every scholar views this technological shift as an issue. James C. Scott, a scholar who studied village communities, argues that many families judge a new tool by whether it helps them survive tough situations, which he called a "subsistence ethic" (Scott). Under this concept, according to Scott, a family is not attempting to ruin their cultural identity or history, but trying to keep their business running during a bad year.

Under this concept, if an artisan decides to use AI descriptions, or to translate their description words into English, it should be understood as an attempt to protect his or her income instead of ruining a tradition. The main reason for this is that traditional craft communities are facing declining revenues as consumer habits shift toward cheap mass production, which is forcing many families to close their workshops ("Fading Traditions"). Therefore, if digital tools allow a workshop to earn more money, they allow the family to keep it running for a longer period of time. For instance, in the mat-weaving community of Vĩnh Phú Đông Commune in Bạc Liêu Province, the number of families practicing the craft dropped significantly from over 500 down to just 90 ("Fading Traditions"). This means more than 80% of the local workshops closed down because they could not compete with cheap and factory-made items. This example shows the predicament that many artisans are already encountering. From this perspective, incorporating the use of AI to sell products online would provide artisans with sufficient income to continue their business.

Conclusion

Two Ways of Weighing the Trade

When observing the issue from a wider scope, there is a struggle between keeping an object's special feeling and helping a family improve its income. On one hand, philosophers like Benjamin and Arendt argued that

using digital tools can hide the voice and value of the artisan, which risks turning a unique handmade item into an online product anyone can purchase. On the other hand, scholars such as Scott contend that the reality is that change is usually necessary to maintain a source of income. More specifically, if an artisan cannot sell their crafts, the village traditions will fade away anyway, meaning that it is essential to sell hand-crafted products using the internet with the help of AI in order to maintain the workshop.

Ultimately, whether AI preserves the artisan's voice depends on how an artisan defines the boundary of cultural preservation. To be more precise, an AI algorithm is not capable of sharing the history of a craft work or showcasing the identity of the artisan. However, AI and related technology can help an artisan preserve cultural identity by acting as a practical tool that keeps family businesses running. This is because the artisan's identity would disappear if his or her workshop is no longer running. Consequently, it is up to traditional craft communities to decide whether cultural heritage resides in the artisan's personal voice or in keeping the workshop in business.

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